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CONTEMPORARY USES AND GRATIFICATIONS OF MOBILE PHONE USE AMONG YOUTH: A COMPARATIVE STUDY

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CONTEMPORARY USES AND GRATIFICATIONS OF MOBILE PHONE USE AMONG YOUTH: A COMPARATIVE STUDY

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Abstract

The uses of Mobile phones transcend borders as people remain connected globally. This study explores the reasons youth use mobile phone, the gratifications and satisfaction obtained from using the mobile phone, by comparing the usage and gratifications of mobile phone by gender and nationality.

This study employs the survey method, as the research instrument. A total of 576 youth nationwide (396 Malaysians and 176 non Malaysians) responded to the study. The study incorporated the uses and gratifications theory to understand the uses and gratifications obtained from using the mobile phone among youth.

The gratifications and satisfaction obtained from using the mobile phone are for fashion and/or status, for the fun of it, affection/sociability, relaxation, information seeking and avoidance of public phone hassle aspects. The study also found gender and nationality differences in terms of affection/sociability and avoidance of public phone hassle respectively. Female youth were found to be socially-oriented. Malaysian youth tend to use mobile phones to avoid public phone hassle more than the non Malaysian youth.

1. INTRODUCTION:

The use of Mobile phones has become essential in everyday life for many people around the world. People use them for many reasons, including staying in contact with family members, friends and business partners. The advanced facilities of the mobile phone make it possible for receiving/sending calls, storing Data and taking photos and made the mobile phones their first choice in communication.

In early days of mobile phones in societies, only those in high positions or businessmen could afford to buy a mobile phone, but today everybody can have access to one mobile, even often time more than one.

Studies on mobile phone use have found different gratifications sought and obtained from mobile phone by youth. Youth can be considered the largest group who use mobile phone for many different reasons. There are limited studies conducted to know how youth use mobile phones, what satisfaction they obtained from using them and frequency of usage. The current study attempts to explore the use of mobile phones among youth, to determine the reasons for using mobile phone, the gratifications and satisfaction obtained from using the mobile phone, and to compare the usage and gratifications of mobile phone among youth of different gender and nationality.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1. Uses and Gratifications Theory:

The uses and gratifications theory (U&G) is one of the oldest and influential theories in the field of communication and media research (Roy, 2008). The theory dates back to the mid of last century when the attention of researchers was drawn toward what do people do with media. Wimmer & Dominick (1994) say that U&G started in the beginnings of 1940s, when the researchers initiated the investigation of why the people involve a certain media activities, while others attribute it to Katz' (1959) argument about the dearth of communication research. He says that the field of communication as persuasion was dying, but not all communication fields. (Severin & Tankard, 2001).

Katz (1959) says that the study of campaigns and persuasion are not varied today, as more mass communication researches are rapidly emerging. He points out that the focus of field of communication studies in that time had converted from studying "what do media do with the people" to the opposite direction "what do people do with the media" in order to save itself.

Discussing Berelson's (1959) claim "the field of communication research seems to be withering", Katz (1959) argues that the pioneers of communication field had confined themselves to "measurements of the relative power of various kinds of communication to change opinions, attitudes, and action in the very short run". (p.1). He points out that this has been called in other places as "the study of campaigns". With regard to aforementioned discussion about the irrelevance of communication research, other researchers are optimist as this approach is becoming familiar among scholars in different countries. Katz, Blumler, Gurevitch (1974) argue that the U&G has grown fast and many more direct empirical studies on audience uses and gratifications had emerged in the United States of America, as in other countries in Europe and Asia. In their evaluation on studies on this perspective conducted in different cultural contexts, they have found to have different starting points; but they are generally concerned with: (1) the social and psychological origins of (2) needs which generate (3) expectations of (4) the mass media, or other sources, which lead to (5) differential patterns of media exposure (or engagement

in other activities) resulting in (6) need gratifications and (7) other consequences, perhaps mostly unintended ones. (p.510).

On the other hand, early studies on U&G identified the needs that audiences sought from the media. Katz, Gurevitch & Haas (1973) identified five basic group needs, namely cognitive needs (e.g., acquiring information, knowledge, and understanding); affective needs (e.g., emotion, pleasure, feelings); personal integrative needs (e.g., credibility, stability, and status); social integrative needs (e.g., interacting with family and friends); and tension release needs (e.g., escape and diversion) (p.166).

However, the basic idea about U&G approach is concerned with the ways people use the media (Katz, et.al, 1974). In other words, at the core of U&G lies the assumption that audience members seek out the mass media to satisfy their needs.

In order to understand the relationship between media and audiences, Katz, Blumler, & Gurevitch (1974) present five key assumptions:

1. The audience is conceived as active, i.e., an important part of mass media use is assumed to be goal oriented.
2. In the mass communication process much initiative in linking need gratification and media choice lies with the audience member. This places a strong limitation on theorizing about any form of straight-line effect of media content on attitudes and behavior.
3. The media compete with other sources of need satisfaction. The needs served by mass communication constitute but a segment of the wider range of human needs, and the degree to which they can be adequately met through mass media consumption certainly varies.
4. Methodologically speaking, many of the goals of mass media use can be derived from data supplied by individual audience members themselves- i.e., people are sufficiently self-aware to be able to report their interests and motives in particular cases, or at least to recognize them when confronted with them in an intelligible and familiar verbal formulation.
5. Value judgments about the cultural significance of mass communication should be suspended while audience orientations are explored on their own terms. (p. 10-11).

However, it can be said that the studies of Katz (1959), Katz, Gurevitch, & Haas (1973); and Katz, Blumler, & Gurevitch (1974) situated a theoretical groundwork of building the uses and gratifications approach.

In recent times, the U&G approach has been utilized and applied for a number of new and emerging communication technologies. Many studies on use of Telephone, TV, Radio, Newspapers, internet, mobile phone, and so forth, adopted this approach, and reported different gratifications. For example, in one of the early studies in the area of Telephone uses and gratifications, O'Keefe & Sulanowski (1995) were interested to investigate the gratifications sought from the telephone and differences in behavioral patterns of telephone use. The study found four gratifications sought by respondents from United States of America, i.e. *sociability, entertainment, acquisition, and time management.* The study reported that gender and age were "the strongest indicators of telephone sociability, and, to a slightly lesser extent, of entertainment" (p.927).

Borton (2009) used this approach to identify Reality TV users on gratifications sought and gratifications obtained. The results of this study contributed to the literature on uses and gratifications on reality-based programs by discovering new gratification for reality programming: *personal utility*. The author tried to provide an explanation for this new factor, attributing it as" reality programs have become more individualized and specific in terms of content, they no longer appeal to the wider audience they did in their inception" (p.474).

In the area of online newspapers, Mings (1997) found that for "some audience members' gratifications sought and obtained from print newspapers seem to carry over into audience expectations and uses". Moreover, one of the interesting results in this study is that, those respondents who reported "avoiding print newspapers were unwilling to spend much time with registration processes for online traditional papers, as were those who reported seeking surveillance gratifications from print newspapers".

Similarly, U&G was also employed in the context of internet use. In his study about the motives of internet use in India, Roy (2008) found that the gratification and satisfaction obtained from internet use were: user-friendly, self-development, educational opportunities, convenience in communication, enhancement of self-development, wide exposure, global exchange, and

relaxation. The results of this study were different from what was found by other studies in terms of internet uses and gratifications (Ko, 2002). Ko found four gratifications from internet use: *information, escape, pass time,* and *interactivity.* He argues that these four factors influence the visiting of certain types of websites. Furthermore, Ko, Cho, Robers (2005) found other gratifications sought from interactive advertising: *information, convenience, entertainment, and social interaction.* Those motivations with interaction of human and message influenced attitude toward the site, which, in turn, influenced the attitude towards the brand, which determine the purchase intension.

In a more recent study, Yoo (2011) found four key gratifications sought and obtained from online newspapers use, namely: socialization, entertainment, information seeking, and pastime) for gratifications sought, and four similar factors (socialization, entertainment, information seeking, and pastime) for gratifications obtained. The study also reveals direct effects of three of the gratifications on audience interactivity.

2.2. Mobile Phone and Youth

At its early inception, mobile phones have been extensively adopted by youth at different age groups and at diverse cultural backgrounds. They used it for different reasons, depending on the status, culture and income of the users. Ahmed & Qazi (2011) found, in their study of mobile phone adoption and consumption patterns among university students in Pakistan, that most of the study's sample begun adoption of mobile phone at early stages (10-18 years), and considered it as a requirement for their day-to-day activities. Half of the calls made by the respondents were "directed towards the families; to send or to receive 0-30 text messages a day; make/receive calls of 0-10 minutes a day and spend 0-2 hours a day to avail internet facility via their cell phones"(p.212).

In terms of ownership of mobile phones, Tuckle & O'Neiil (2004) reported that ownership of mobile phone is determined by demographic variables such as: *socioeconomic status, age, employment status, place of residence, and education.* For example, mobile phone ownership increased with of level of education. The study found that 39% of mobile phone owners were non-high school graduate; 51% of owners were high school graduates; 78% owners were college graduate; and 82% were postgraduate youth.

With regard to gender differences, Haverila (2011) examined the behavioral aspects of mobile phone adoption among Finland youth, and found four factors that determined behavioral adoption of mobile phone. These factors included: *cost efficiency, functionality, necessity in modern times, and safety/security.* The study found a significant gender difference with regard to these factors. It revealed that female youth placed more concern on the "security and safety" factor, and place less concern on "functionality factors".

Walsh, White, & Young (2007) report that the most mentioned advantage by users was the ability to "quickly and easily contact others in spite of geographical distance or time constraints" (p.6). They reported youth used their mobile phones to look for social support whenever they feel lonely or depressed. They also used for "practical purposes" like organizing transport and sometimes for emergencies. Other studies (Economides & Grousopoulou, 2008) report others' uses of mobile phone such communication via phone and SMS with family and friends. Most of studies investigated mobile phone adoption among youth revealed almost similar age groups (i.e., 18-40 years old).

2.3. Mobile Phone and U&G:

The Uses and Gratifications theoretical approach has been applied in the telecommunication sector, particularly to study the use of mobile phone. Wei & Lo (2006) suggest that the U&G approach offers suitable framework for studying the mobile phone, asserting that different individuals seek out diverse media and use it differently.

The U&G approach has provided some reasons and motives for using, and results of, mobile phone in different countries such as Hong Kong (Leung & Wei, 2000); Australia (Walsh, White, & Young, 2007); United states of America (Stafford & Gillenson, 2004); Taiwan (Wei & Lo, 2006; Ho & Syu, 2010); and Singapore (Chua, Goh, & Lee, 2012). To date, there is no single study on mobile phone uses and gratifications among youth in Malaysia.

The previous research by the scholars on U&G approach revealed different gratifications sought and obtained from the mobile phone use. For instance, the Wei & Lo's (2006) study on college students in a university in Taiwan revealed six gratifications of mobile phone: affection, social utility, fashion-status, information-seeking, mobility, and accessibility. The results showed that

affection appeared as the best predictors of how students made calls to families, relatives and friends. Moreover, it shows a gender difference in mobile phone use for both family-oriented and social-oriented calls.

The study by Wei & Lo also found that affection and accessibility gratifications were negatively correlated with loneliness, while *fashion-status* was positively correlated with loneliness. Furthermore, it found a negatively correlation between shyness and *social utility* and *affection*, after controlling the influence of social structure and mass-media variables.

On the other hand, Leung & Wei (2000) found seven gratifications for use of mobile phones among the respondents from Hong Kong. The gratifications sought from the mobile phone included fashion/status, affection/sociability, relaxation, mobility, immediate access, instrumentality, and reassurance. They found that the mobility, immediacy and instrumentality were the best predictors of gratifications of mobile phone. Similar to Wei & Lo (2006), they found gender differences in the use and gratifications of mobile phone. Their study found that "male users tend to use cellular phone as an instrument to do business and younger females tended to make longer calls while on the go" (p.317).

Moreover, in their study on psychological influences of mobile phone usage amongst Australian youth, Walsh, White, & Young (2007) found three gratifications sought by the youth from the mobile phone, namely: *self*, *social*, and *security*. The results suggest that the level of use and addictive tendencies were predicted by social and self gratifications, whereas security gratifications did not show any significant prediction for level of use and addictive indicators.

In a recent study, Ho & Syu (2010) conducted a study of mobile phone uses and gratifications focusing on its applications. They found two gratifications, namely: relaxing and relieving stress. The study revealed no gratification for "learning different languages", "being personal assistant", and "obtaining real-time information". It also found no difference among gender and income groups. It found a difference among education and age groups.

More recently, Chua, Goh, & Lee (2012), in their study about mobile phone content contribution and retrieval among students in two large universities in Singapore, found "perceived gratification factors for mobile content contribution were found to be different from those for mobile retrieval" (p.20). They found five gratification factors for mobile content contribution: *leisure, access, self, socialization,* and *relationship maintenance.* On the other hand, they found four gratification factors for mobile content retrieval: *Information resources/services, leisure, information quality, and socialization.*

There is a need to understand how youth make use of mobile phones and to know the differences, if any kind, exist between the different nationalities. We would assume that there would be differences, as illustrated in figure 1.

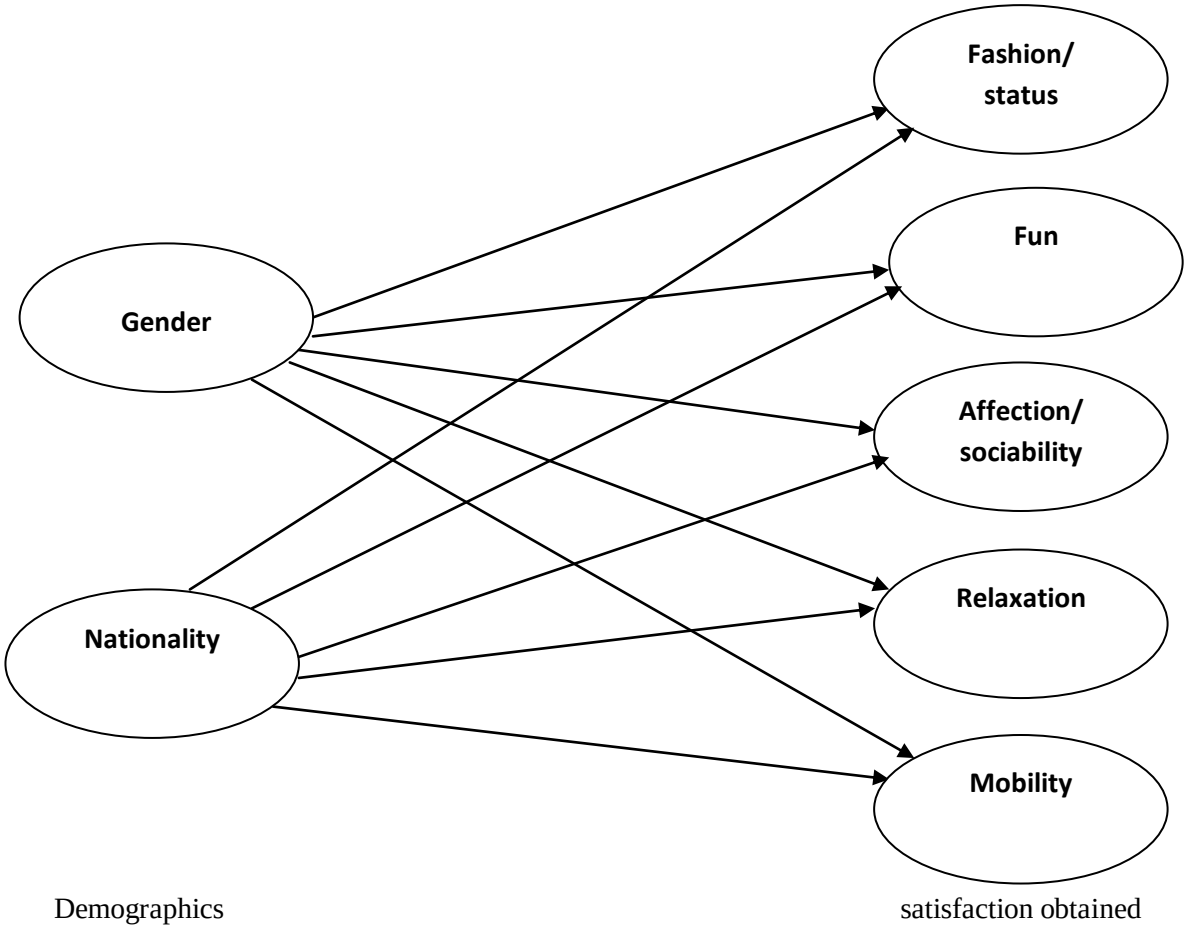

Figure 1: Gratification obtained from Mobile Phone use in terms of usage, gender and nationality

2.4. Gender difference and U&G

In most studies, the demographic variables brought differences in choice, preference, uses, motives, and intensions of the studied population. Gender variable may sometimes influence the intensions of the respondents with regard to given phenomenon, and this depends on many factors including cultural patterns.

Several studies have revealed that the gender was a better predictor in the use of mobile phone among diverse cultural backgrounds. For example, Leung & Wei (2000) found that differences in gratifications sought from the mobile phone were different by gender. They found that male users were more likely to use mobile phone as an instrument in order to do business, whereas younger females are more likely to use it for longer calls.

Similarly, Wei & Lo (2006) found that female and male users sought different gratifications from mobile phone. They found gender to be the best predictor of using mobile phone in both family-oriented and social-oriented situations. The gratifications of mobile phone that revealed a significant difference with regard to gender include information seeking, affection, and mobility. Female users are more likely to use mobile phones for expression of affection and to benefit from the mobility of the wireless technology, while male users are more likely to use it for seeking information. However, the authors conclude that gender mediates how users take advantage of the mobile phone to keep social relationships.

Most of the researches conducted on mobile phones focused on the capabilities of the technology and human ability to shape that technology into solutions to a spectrum of different needs. Investigations on this device have also been done around the globe. Hijazi-Omari & Ribak (2008) investigated Palestinian girls' romantic conversation. Ekanjume, (2009) examined social relationships among Lesotho University's staff members using text messages. To date, limited number of researchers has conducted a study on mobile phone usage among youth of different nationalities.

Based on the literature review and the afore-mentioned model, we propose the following research hypothesis:

H1: ***There would be a significant difference between male and female youth in terms of gratifications obtained from mobile phone use.***

We hardly find any study on the use of mobile phone among different nationalities. We would assume that different nationalities make use of mobile phones for different reasons. Then we propose the following research hypothesis:

H2*: There would be a significant difference between Malaysian and international youth in terms of gratifications obtained from mobile phone* use.

3. Methodology:

A survey was used to elicit responses from the youth in nationwide survey. The study uses cluster and stratified random sample, and it is based on gender and nationality. The data were collected in December 2011 from a total of 576 youth respondents nationwide.

The survey instrument comprised of 27 items of motivations for using the mobile phone. Each item was measured on a five-point scale from 1= strongly unsatisfied, 2= unsatisfied, 3= slightly satisfied, 4= satisfied, 5= strongly satisfied.

4. Findings

4.1. Demographic profile:

More than two thirds of the respondents were Malaysian youth (69%), and less than one third were international youth (31%). In terms of gender, there is a slightly difference between the proportion of male youth (55%) compared to female youth (45%). The respondents' age was between 17 and 40 years old, with the majority of them fall under the category of 21-25 (49%). There were more youth (38%) who studied or were still studying university. Three quarters of the youth who responded to this study were single (75%), where as less than quarter was married (19%). The occupations included student (64%), private sector employee (13%), government staff (9), self-employed (5%), school pupil (4%) and unemployed (3%).

4.2. Factor analysis:

Based on the literature on uses and gratifications of mobile phone, we listed out 27 items distributed in five variables: *fashion/status, fun, affection/sociability, relaxation, and mobility.* A factor analysis for all items was conducted. All items were involved in the factor loadings process, resulting in six factor loadings. Table 1 shows the loadings, reliability, Eigen values and % of variance.

Based on the analysis, there are six components (factors) extracted. Factor 1 is labeled as "*relaxation*" and consisted of five items; factor 2 is "*affection/sociability"*; consisted of five items; factor 3 is "*information seeking"* (five items); factor 4 is "*fashion and/or status"* (four items); factor 5 is "fun" (five items); and factor 6 is "*avoidance of public phone hassle"* (three items). The items of the factor "mobility" were found to be divided into two factors: *information seeking and avoidance of public phone hassle.* It was observed that the fourth factor

“fashion/status” had obtained the highest cronbach’s alpha (0.948), while the first factor (affection/sociability) had the highest Eigen value of 10.402, the remaining factor loadings were found to have an Eigen value greater than one. The first factor explained 39% of the variance, followed by the second factor (13%), third factor (8%), fourth factor (7), fifth factor (6%), and sixth factor (4%).

4.3. Analyses by gender:

An independent t-test was run to explore the gratifications obtained by male and female youth from using mobile phone. The analysis shows a significant difference between male and female in terms of affection/sociability gratifications. Female youth (M=4.35) tend to gratify affection/sociability from using mobile phone more than the male youth (M=4.21). In other words, female youth are more socially-oriented than the male youth. The other gratifications obtained from using mobile phone did show any significant difference between male and female youth. It means that youth seek similar gratifications irrespective of gender.

Table 1: Principle Component Analysis, with Varimax Rotation for the 27 items

Factors	Items	Factor loadings	Reliability	Eigen values	% of variance
	1. To enjoy the pleasure of talking to people	0.688			
		0.791			
1	2. To chat.	0.837			
	3. To be less bored by calling people.	0.831	**0.908**	**10.402**	**38.52**
	4. Using the phone relaxes me				
	5. To help pass time	0.782			
	1. To feel closer to family members.	0.752			
	2. To improve relationship with family.	0.854			
2	3. To allow parents to carry out family responsibilities while at work.	0.804			
	4. To let others know you care for them	0.779			
	5. To being always available to the children or with my brothers/sister	0.723	**0.897**	**3.390**	**12.56**
	1. To tell others you will be late during a traffic jam	0.657			
		0.742			
	2. Immediate access to facilities	0.833			
3	3. To be always be available to anyone no matter where are you	0.837	**0.904**	**2.260**	**8.37**
	4. To provide immediate access to others anywhere anytime	0.758			
	5. To be available to the ill or aged members of the family				
	1. To look stylish	0.904			
	2. To look fashionable	0.907			
4	3. To have it as a status symbol	0.889			
	4. To avoid looking old-fashioned without a mobile phone	0.816	**0.948**	**1.863**	**6.90**
	1. It is interesting	0.671			
	2. It is convenient	0.835			
	3. It is easy	0.851			
5	4. It is useful	0.757	**0.887**	**1.649**	**6.11**
	5. It is awesome	0.612			
	1. To eliminate the need for change as coins are required to use a public phone	0.840			
		0.809			
6	2. To eliminate the need to queue for a public phone	0.803	**0.903**	**1.030**	**3.82**
	3. To avoid the need for a fixed public phone any more				

Note: scale for uses and gratifications items were “1”= strongly disagree, to “5” = strongly agree.

4.4. Analysis by nationality:

An independent t-test was also employed to investigate whether there is a significant difference between Malaysian and non Malaysian youth. The results did not show any significant difference between the two groups in terms of the six factors except for one factor (avoidance of public phone hassle). Malaysian youth (M=4.02) used mobile phones to avoid public phone hassle more than international youth (M= 3.82). It means that Malaysian youth use the mobile phone to eliminate the need to queue for a public phone, to eliminate the need for change as coins are required to use a public phone, as well as to stay away from the need of looking for a fixed public phone any more.

5. Discussion:

The present study sought to investigate the use of mobile phone among youth, to elucidate the gratification and satisfaction obtained from using the mobile phone, and to compare the usage and gratifications of mobile phone among youth of different gender and nationality. The study found six factors from the process of factor analysis. The last factor (mobility) which comprised 8 items was found to have two factors: *information seeking and avoidance of public phone hassle*.

Differences in gratifications obtained from using mobile phone were related to difference in demographics of users. The gratifications aspects of affection and avoidance of public phone hassle were found to be different by gender and nationality respectively. Thus, our hypothess were partially supported.

The results show significant difference between male and female only in terms of affection/sociability. Female youth tend to use mobile phone for social relationship more than the male youth. Thus, H1 was partially supported. This result is consistent with previous studies (Leung & Wei, 2000; Wei & Lo, 2006) that found gender to be best predictor in the gratifications sought and obtained from the use of mobile phone. Leung & Wei, (2000) found gender difference in terms of affection. Their study reveals that female youth tend to use mobile phone for longer calls. Similarly Wei & Lo (2006) found that "women rely more heavily than men on extensive use of cell phones to show affection to their families while they were on the move" (p.68). However, we find evidence here with the notion that the gender difference in traditional telephone seems to be extended to mobile phone use (Leung & Wei, 2000).

Furthermore, the current study found a new gratification sought by youth from using the mobile phone. It was observed difference in gratifications obtained from mobile phone between Malaysian and non Malaysian youth. The results suggest that Malaysian youth tend to use mobile phones to gratify avoidance of public phone hassle more than the non Malaysian youth. Therefore, H2 was also partially supported. However, our study contributes to the limited studies of international youth who were studying in Malaysia. Perhaps the situation they were in required to seek the use of the mobile phones to use in contact with their loved ones in their own country. There was no necessity for such among Malaysian youth. Future studies should expand the sample and focus on specific nations in order to understand more about the differences in using mobile phone in different societies.

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